

‘Redneck Customs’: race and class at the demolition derby

Susan Falls*

Savannah College of Art and Design, Anthropology – Liberal Arts, Savannah, GA, USA

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Using data collected from ethnographic research at demolition derbies in New York, New Jersey and Pennsylvania, this article focuses on the language used by drivers for car-naming practices in response to epithets routinely associated with rural, working-class whites. Briefly cast into mass consciousness by media coverage of the racialised 2008 US Presidential contest through a focus on the ‘Appalachian Belt’, the day-to-day experiences of rural working-class whites tend to stay below the news radar. This population, often publicly referred to by terms like ‘white trash’ or ‘rednecks’, has also received relatively little scholarly attention. That such language is used unproblematically in the public arena underscores the construction of the working-class white as embodying a complex mixture of racial privilege and class disadvantage. And while emerging studies of whiteness do address ‘redneck’ as a racialised class category, and research on poor rural Americans is attracting more researchers, studies on leisure activity associated with rural whites is very scarce. But over a million fans attend more than 2000 demolition derby events every year, and as a site where values centred on nationalism, citizenship and class are practiced and critiqued; I use the metaphor of creative destruction to explore the derby as a remarkable model of expressive culture and site of active resistance.

Keywords: race; countryside; culture; leisure; popular culture; recreation

A refurbished black Lincoln Town Car shoots flames out of homemade pipes welded to the hood, spins its wheels and sprays gravel shrapnel into the raucous fairground crowd. The driver revs the engine, takes aim and then hits the gas. He slams headlong into the side of a green Chrysler, mooring it onto a log, where its tires spin helplessly in the dust-choked air. ‘ZHHHHHEEE Blam! Whoooo-hoo-ooooo! BrO, d’ja see that? He slammed ‘em! Hooooo-wee!’, a man behind me shouts to his wife and young kids. It has only been a few minutes since the start of the derby, but already there are only two cars left running in the first heat. The rest of the cars sit crumpled and still (well, one is smoking) while the crowd cheers, madly encouraging the remaining drivers to go after one another. Pretty soon, only one car is left; the lone driver cuts the engine and crawls through the window to stand on the hood. Such was the content of an early field note entry (edited for readability), describing what I saw and heard at my first demolition derby in a New Jersey field turned fairground.

*Email: sfalls@scad.edu

I would attend dozens of demolition derbies at county fairs in New York, New Jersey and Pennsylvania during the summer of 2007 and in the years following. While I spent a lot of time in the stands with the audience, the pit pass I usually acquired gave me access to drivers, crew and cars. I interviewed anyone that would talk to me and took lots of photographs (the derby is particularly photogenic, as reflected in visual-essays like that by Lowenberg [see Byles, 2005; Humphrey, 1998; Lowenburg, 2005]). My goal was to study the derby as an example of rural US leisure, a topic that has received surprisingly little scholarly attention. While most ethnographic research in the USA examines urban, indigenous and/or border populations, there is a tradition of high-quality work on rural North America, as Adams pointed out in her review of historical and current anthropological and sociological work on rurality (Adams, 2007). She pointed out that this literature has tended to focus on poverty, acculturation of immigrants and migrants, and issues related to agricultural production; contemporary work expands this tradition by considering how gender, ethnicity, borders, environmental impact, and so forth, shape community dynamics. It is telling that there was no mention of work related to what might be considered leisure.

But, the study of leisure cast many elements of human experience into relief, and while there are excellent studies of the rural as a site of urbanite leisure (Bunce, 1994; Snape, 2004; Snape & Pussard, 2009; Urry, 2002; Williams, 1975; Wordsworth, (1835) 2012), and some on the leisure activity of rural residents (Hendry et al., 2002; Nauta, 1988; Ruben & Ruiter, 2002), it remains a relatively untapped research site (a recent review of 3751 articles published in leisure research journals found that only 1.5% cited rurality as a significant part of their research (Edwards & Matarrita-Cascante, 2011)). As for me, I was interested in exploring how a distinctly ruralite activity, like the demolition derby, may be more than just a pastime.

This article uses the metaphor of 'creative destruction' to explore aesthetic, sensual and political elements that make derbying a meaningful activity that not only expresses community values, but also the potential for lasting consequences in terms of identity production, particularly with regard to race. I argue that *car naming* (giving cars a special name to distinguish it over and above an assigned derby number) is a practice through which derbies talk back to the political and economic forces that not only shape the US car industry, but also produce the complex hierarchy of racialised class positions to which they are subject.

The derby

I was struck by the palpable sense of community, excitement and joyful catharsis at the derby fairgrounds. I found the crashes surprisingly exhilarating, and judging by the reactions of spectators, drivers, officials and everyone else in attendance, the feeling was mutual. I was soon to discover that the derby has a long history of festive participation.

Demolition derbies have been around for over 60 years, and more than a million fans – mostly poor and working-class whites – attend the over 2000 demolition derby events held every year (Byles, 2005). The derby is one of the most dramatic displays of contemporary expressive culture available for rural white communities today (Lowenburg, 2005). And just as Geertz (1973) read the Balinese cockfight as a locus for the expression of culture, the derby can be understood as a place where cultural values surrounding race and class, particularly proletarian whiteness, are simultaneously reproduced and vetted.¹

In a social history approach to the car crash as entertainment, Vardi (2011a) showed that the demolition derby crash extravaganza was supported by the auto industry. A professional milieu of wreckers, highly involved with the economic interests of industry, popularised their antics in the context of the emerging method of planned obsolescence (2011b). Popular accounts place its origins, with this industry support, at the Islip Speedway on Long Island, New York in the 1950s, and although the rules have changed as it has become more commercial, the basic tools, strategies and goals remain the same: the last running car able to hit another car wins (Humphrey, 1998). This seems like a fairly straight-forward game, but strategy, technological know-how and a little luck are crucial for a victory. The stakes are not high, but drivers explained to me that the potential for glory, a trophy and the 'unbelievable rush' is what draws men, and even some women, to participate.

Marsden showed that aside from some accounts of history and popularity, there has been surprisingly little scholarship on the US county fair given its persistence (Marsden, 2010). But, fairs serve many purposes, one of which is raising money for the community. Animal shows, art sales and tickets can all generate revenue, but the derby brings in the largest crowds and the most money. The fair is also a place to make community as participants engage in small talk, meet neighbours and greet newcomers while they exhibit their horses or handcrafts. Fairs usually take place in an open field out on a county road over a period of several days. Young children and adults wander through livestock stalls filled with goats, oxen and cows against a backdrop of brightly lit rides with familiar names like 'Tilt-a-Whirl' or 'Himalayan'; they play well-loved games such as 'Whack-A-Mole', where they may or may not win a giant stuffed animal or a blow-up ball. Local schools exhibit student work and display banners bragging about championships or special awards. Hunger is met by the traditional selection of cotton candy, fried 'onion blossoms', and Italian sausage. Surrounding the animals, games and food, are booths where local artisans and small businesses sell everything from earrings and change purses to sunroom additions and farm equipment.

Major community institutions are also represented. Churches sponsor tents and offer prayers alongside government desks that distribute information about local matters, for example highway deaths or roadwork accidents. Political parties, 4-H clubs and senior citizen groups staff tables for outreach, tempting fairgoers with high-powered fans, lemonade or free stickers. I was not surprised to see military recruiters wearing the latest in 'digital camo', showing off small tanks and chatting with deployed soldiers' wives, children and parents while extolling the virtues of service to young people in places where a college education is the exception rather than the rule (United States Census, 2000). Fairs all over the region share these features, and the derby itself conforms to a standard routine.

To prepare the arena, firemen pour water on a large dirt pit bounded by logs or concrete barriers. The front loader that mixes the mud will later push 'dead' cars out of the way. The wet ground prevents the area from becoming enveloped in a gaze-obscuring dust cloud as well as handicapping speed: the slick surface prevents drivers from accelerating too fast, so there are few injuries. Fans take to the bleachers hours before the event is scheduled to begin (usually around sunset, which, when coupled with the lights of the Ferris wheel, provides dramatic scenery for crashes). Music, mostly thematic tunes like Tom Cochran's 'Life is A Highway', blares for an audience that, reflecting county demographics, is largely white and

working class. A few racial or ethnic minorities might accompany a white partner, spouse or date. Adding a bit of class diversity, there may be white-collar families from New York or Philadelphia headed by fathers wearing what is known in the business world as ‘casual weekend wear’ – khakis, loafers, button-down shirts or T-shirts proclaiming college loyalty to ‘NYU’ or ‘Penn State’. Groups of youthful goths or hipsters expressing a transgressive sensibility through tattoos or piercings also dot the crowd. The atmosphere is friendly: fans chat with family, neighbours and strangers – as people watching, acquaintance-making and community-building characterise the pre-event activity (see Figure 1).

As the bleachers fill, teams haul cars in on trailers. Drivers, who work by day as auto mechanics or with larger vehicles as road or construction workers or farm equipment operators, deliver finishing touches to their cars in ‘the pit’ (an area reserved for cars, drivers and crewmembers), making them run as well as they can while still meeting regulations. The mood is sociable: teams borrow tools, tips, and advice from one another, although rivalries and bitter hostilities occasionally develop. Officials lecture drivers on regulations:

No teamwork! Stay off of the driver’s door. I know you guys can do it ‘cause I seen you, and if I see you hit that drivers’ door, I will give you a red flag and you will be out. No warning this time.

Anyone can enter, but requirements like ‘move battery next to the firewall (heater box area)’ and ‘cut transmission cooler lines at transmission and join them together (hose and clamps)’, ensure that only those with mechanical experience, or the ability to find someone who does, can build a competitive entry. Windows are removed, doors are welded shut and a host of safety precautions make the derby very driver-friendly. And, although I saw a few women participating (there are also ‘powder-puff’ events for women only), most drivers and crew in this celebration of machismo are male.

The crowd comes together when the announcer asks everyone to stand for the National Anthem. One or two local women lead, ‘O! Say can you see by the dawn’s early light ...’ Just about everyone participates in the singing. Many are



Figure 1. Fans gather to save seats for friends and family well before the action starts. Photo by Author.

wearing Stars and Stripes bandanas, or 'SUPPORT OUR TROOPS' t-shirts, and some cars sport pro-US military messages or yellow ribbons painted on them. In the only solemn moment of the evening, nationalism is conflated with Christianity as the announcer invites his generally patriotic, religious audience to pray for the safety and healthful return of soldiers from the community who are serving in Iraq or Afghanistan, asking God to bless the troops and our country. Afterwards, drivers bring their cars into the arena for the first heat as each name, car number and hometown is announced, '... and here comes Mike Martin in Car #8 from Ballston Spa, New York'. Echoing Nascar racing norms, some cars have 'sponsors': some are real local companies like 'Mike Swain Construction' or 'Appletree Childcare', but as often as not they are 'sponsored' by made-up companies like 'Wreck 'Em Motors'. These invented names are the subject of this paper.

The announcer calls to the drivers: 'Drivers, can you hear me? Check your seatbelts and helmets! Raise your hand if you have a problem'. When all drivers signal ready, the announcer calls out: 'Help me now!' The crowd yells, 'Ten, nine, eight, seven ...' At the bottom of the countdown, cars rev their engines, put them in reverse, and 'gun it' backwards towards the other cars in an attempt to disable them as quickly and decisively as possible. The derby is extremely loud, high-powered and boisterous, but with so many rules, real danger is constrained. I never saw anyone suffer an injury other than some mild whiplash, even though cars sometimes do catch on fire, at which point the crowd shrieks wildly and the derby is suspended while local firefighters rush out to extinguish the flames.

When only one car is left running, the winner is announced. The driver emerges and raises his arms in victory. Friends surround him while kids clamour to talk to the winner, getting an autograph or perhaps picking up a piece of destroyed car as a souvenir. Meanwhile, crewmembers survey the damage as front loaders or tow trucks clear the field. In between heats, mothers purchase soda or popcorn for hungry families and strangers 'save seats' while someone visits the Port-a-Potty. Fans line up at booths staffed by older women selling hats, t-shirts and other paraphernalia ('And we have ladies scoop neck t-shirts for the first time this year!') directs the announcer to the 'merch'). The final heat follows the same routine, but the ultimate winner receives a larger trophy and is even more rowdily revered. Cash awards are minimal, typically cancelling out the time and resources put into the vehicle. If the derby is not, then, about pursuing capital, what makes it worthwhile?

Creative destruction

With its standardised rules and tropes, the derby is bracketed from everyday activity. In this staged event, normal actions and reactions are suspended. Special measures ensure pleasure and safety. Large nets between the bleachers and the arena prevent flying debris from causing injury, while the fire department stands by in case someone is seriously hurt. When cars are annihilated, onlookers, rather than gasping in horror, are happy, elated even. When a damaged vehicle takes yet another violent hit, crowds cheer louder still. The worst-looking cars are wildly fêted. 'Sandbaggers', those who avoid collisions, are booed. But although bracketed, the derby remains best explained within the framework of larger society, with its particular social, political and economic organisation.

Social scientists have analysed the derby as a highly sensual example of 'costly signaling', wherein males demonstrate genetic fitness through dramatic, public

display (Vogel, 2006), as a rite of passage, in which the derby marks the production of masculinity within sodalities of race and gender in late-capitalist USA under the conditions of liberal governmentality (Graves, Lipman, & Werry, 2003), and, as a rite of reversal (Jewett & Lawrence, 1976; Zehr, 1994). Usually discussed in terms of van Gennep's work on ritual ((1909) 1960), rites of reversal help maintain social order by functioning as safety valves, easing built-up tensions through a temporary inversion of conventional hierarchies, norms and relationships. Minstrel shows of the 1800s in the USA (that made explicit social and political conflict) and the rites of ancient Roman Saturnalia (where slaves become masters) are examples in which tensions generated through racial mores and social hierarchy are addressed, but ultimately reproduced. Likewise, mainstream, and therefore largely middle-class conventions associated with US society, such as the presentation of self as an aspirationally classed subject and a psychological, social and physical dependency on the car, are inverted in stark form at the derby.

Another obvious inversion of values is in the pointed destruction of a premier symbol of productive citizenry and conformity: the car. Since there are few places to live with social or physical ease without at least occasional access to one, the car is deeply implicated in the fabric of US society (Fatality Analysis Reporting System, 2007). Most people drive to work, usually alone (Bureau of Transportation, 2001). We drive to shop, to travel or simply to pass time. Not having a car makes finding employment of choice nearly impossible. Meanwhile, public transportation remains deeply stigmatised, and with the exception of New York, and to an extent San Francisco, most people avoid it altogether since it is not only inconvenient, but relatively expensive. It is revealing that after housing, the car is cited as Americans' most important possession (McAlinden, Hill, Swieki, & The Center for Advanced-Automotive Research, 2003). On a personal level, these machines are used to communicate status, style and autonomy. And like other consumables, cars help make identity claims with respect to class, generation or nationalism.

Cars also work within a larger context. As the physical landscape has developed in tandem with cars (Jackson, 1984, 1985), so have economic and political configurations. The automotive industry is not only a major lobbying powerhouse and political contributor, but is a crucial pillar in the financial system.² Relatedly, the US automobile manufacturers association slogan, 'What America drives, drives America', depicts the tip of the economic iceberg that is US car culture. The auto industry, the largest in the world, contributes billions of dollars per year to the economy and constitutes around 10% of employment, which is why, its recent decline notwithstanding, it will not be allowed to fail (McAlinden et al., 2003).³

So, in demolishing cars – cars that index political economy – the derby can be interpreted as a rite of reversal that curbs the aggression felt by those under the heel of capitalism while all the while re-inscribing the status quo (Jewett & Lawrence, 1976). In a similar vein, Zehr used actor/network theory to show that what 'automobile culture forces users not to do in their everyday lives, is reversed and revenged on the night of the derby' (Zehr, 1994). However, the derby can also be read as a site of creative destruction that provides an opportunity for reclaiming alienated skills and labour, expressing a home-grown Do-It-Yourself aesthetic and serving as an implicit critique of racialised class structures. Inspired by Gregory Bateson's analysis of the Itatmul Naven ceremony from competing sociological lenses (Bateson, 1958), my claim is not that the derby is either costly consumption, a rite of reversal or creative destruction, but rather that these lenses, and possibly

others (related to gender, nationalism, phenomenology, etc.) can each, or together in concert, cast into relief the range of meaningful social experiences prompted by participation in it.

The term ‘creative destruction’ is perhaps best known to western scholars via Schumpeter’s *Capitalism, Socialism and Democracy* (1942), where it is used, somewhat teleologically, to describe innovative, competitive entrepreneurial waves (particularly in technology) that can produce short-term economic volatility but also hasten capitalism’s transformation towards democratic socialism. Schumpeter’s book has been influential and was thought highly original when published, but as Reinert and Reinert (2006) have argued, the expression ‘creative destruction’ has a deeper history.

Reinert and Reinert show that Schumpeter’s use of ‘creative destruction’ derives in part from the work of a lesser-known economist, Werner Sombart. Sombart, strongly influenced by Nietzsche, understood the will to power/to create as a basis of economic development and the underpinning of creative destruction.⁴ During the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, the German intelligentsia became intrigued by Indian thought, particularly Hinduism with its tripartite creator, preserver and destroyer deities (sometimes contained within the figure of Shiva). Schopenhauer and Herder, for example, were both fascinated by Indian philosophy. It was within this context that the dialectic of creation and destruction was ushered into the western academy, however read or perhaps misread through Nietzsche it was (especially in Thus Spake Zarathustra, (Nietzsche, (1883–1885) 1978)). Although he did not use the term ‘creative destruction’, Nietzsche described a non-teleological, and therefore risky, attack that was spearheaded by the ‘noble man’ on the existing moral regime supported by ‘good and just’ conservative forces in society, so that it might be replaced by a new, yet partly unseen order, manifest in his *Übermensch* (translated as ‘super man’ or ‘over man’). Destruction precedes creation. Moving forwards requires annihilation. Will to power demolishes status quo.

Without exaggerating the possibilities of derby activity, I adapt ‘creative destruction’ to describe a process by which existing practices and values are cast into relief, disrupted or even destroyed, and something new (and perhaps unexpected) can develop as a result – not on the level of an entire economic system or social order, but on a modest individual scale, which is where social transformation, after all, can begin. As Rojek has shown:

the common – sense notion that leisure is primarily about play and relaxation, or that it can be compartmentalized or segregated from the rest of life, [gives way to] the more radical proposition that leisure is always and already, political. (Rojek, 2005)

I would like to examine the derby as a leisure activity that allows for small but nonetheless political consequences, rather than as playful relaxation which merely reproduces existing social orders. To show how the derby is a site for drivers to exert a sense of agency – however weak its structural effects – I will press the derby as a reversal rite as a precursor to reading it through the complementary metaphor of creative destruction.

As a rite of reversal, audiences cheer at accidents, particularly when fire, liquid, tires and other debris fly through the air, and they feel disappointed when there are no explosions, as reflected in one fan’s remark: ‘It was a good derby and all, but I really wanted to see something blow-up!’ Middle-class notions of decorum,

exaggerated concerns with safety and values regarding legitimate leisure are exuberantly snubbed. Drivers, crew and even spectators, many of whom work long hours to make enough money to maintain a car and a home, thrill and delight in the destruction, the sensuality of the chase and the joy of being contrary, all of which contribute to the 'unbelievable rush' described to me by many drivers. Everyone takes pleasure in the derby's disobedience, although it is within confines of rules about how to disobey.

Ritualised status reversal is correlated with permanent structural inferiority (Turner, 1969). In its more basic formulation, rites of reversal are thought to provide a platform for voicing dissent and for releasing built-up tensions, but they are symbolic events, not acts of true resistance. Emotionally, these rituals are soothing and cathartic, but they are not even neutral social acts. As social safety valves, they can even strengthen normative social rules and relationships; functional social theory might explain their existence by virtue of this consequence. For example, after Saturnalia, slaves who played master returned to being slaves. Minstrel shows seemed to have entrenched racism and hardened harmful stereotypes.

Rites of reversal are therefore, and perhaps contrary to subjective experience, inherently conservative. Creative destruction, by contrast, as configured in economic theory, Hinduism and even Nietzschean philosophy, is potentially radical, effecting lasting change. This aspect of creative destruction is present in the derby: while derbying certainly can be viewed as temporary reversal, and the derby does conserve social norms such as class hierarchy, patriotism and religiosity, there are, at least for some participants, opportunities to resist, reframe or at least talk back to these structures. Using rite of reversal and creative destruction as complementary lenses provides us with an enhanced understanding of how this activity might simultaneously support the only seemingly countervailing processes of structure and agency.

The effects of derbying can occur on both an individual and the social level. For example, while drivers and audiences go back to their jobs when the fair is over, and derbying does not address, much less change, the architecture of capitalism with its reliance on alienated wage-labour (which has particular salience for these men), it does allow derbiers to reframe their own everyday understandings of class as an economic and racial category. Derbying is empowering, which means that participants report feeling different as a result of involvement – as emasculated or classed subjects, or as family-makers. This is perhaps its most important feature. The potential for subjective transformation makes it more than a temporary, merely symbolic, spectacle of inversion. Of the many ways that derbying is a potentially radical practice of creative destruction. I next focus on drivers' critique of racialised class.

'Redneck Customs'

Even as the racialised class position occupied by working-class whites reflects a complex nexus of history, privilege and prejudice, Harrison (1995) notes that a systematic study of whiteness by scholars long invested in examining the construction of race is quite recent. But whose whiteness is under scrutiny? Brodtkin (2001, p. 147) argued that a significant tension in work on whiteness is expressed in the 'game of academic one-upmanship, often played by pitting the variability of whiteness against the historical continuity of its family of tropes'. Thus, work that foregrounds enduring tropes is criticised for not attending to how whiteness, defined in

relation to a panoply of whitenesses, is synchronically diverse and historically fluid. Likewise, analyses that foreground diversity and fluidity are subject to the criticism that they erase historically persistent meanings and contents of whiteness (Brodin, 2001; Hartigan, 1997; Waterson, 2006).

Over time, scholars have shifted away from characterising whiteness as a practice of privilege set in opposition to racialised non-white others and toward an examination of whiteness as a heterogeneous and plastic category understood in connection with non-racial factors such as class, ethnicity, gender, religion, nationality, occupation, sexuality and age (Doane & Bonilla-Silva, 2003; Frankenberg, 1997; Hartigan, 2005; Kincheloe, Steinberg, Rodriguez, & Chennault, 1998; Lutz & Collins, 1993; Rasmussen, Mexico, Klinenberg, & Wray, 2001; Roediger, 1999; Waterson, 2006; Wray & Newitz, 1996).⁵ Not Quite White, Wray's (2006) book about the shifting discursive constructions of 'white trash', captures the internal complexity of whiteness, shown as anything but a simple racial construct. The phrase itself – 'not quite white' – reflects how, within whiteness, there is a hegemonic whiteness to which poor whites, such as derbiers, may not belong (Lewis, 2004). And while theoretical work engages whiteness' historical continuity, local empirical study on particular instances of whiteness make it increasingly difficult to subsume white experience under one generic rubric, since it reveals whiteness as a set of hyphenated whitenesses whose members' relationship to privilege is variable, particularly with regard to class.

A review of the literature shows that whitenesses under ethnographic scrutiny are most often attached to poor or middle-class urbanites and suburbanites (Hartigan, 1999; Kenny, 2000; Lewis, 2001; Perry, 2001). Rural poor and working-class whites make up a significant portion of the US public, yet studies addressing their racialised experience are relatively few, and while rural labour does seem to be attracting more attention – such as Striffler's (2005) exploration of immigrant chicken factory workers – studies of leisure by rural poor or working-class whites are truly scarce. But understanding the construction of whiteness by and for this population is necessary as it refracts larger dynamics of identity, power and inequality, and since leisure can theatricise these larger dynamics, pointed research in these sites is wanted.

Since drivers and crew use a linguistic mode of creative destruction to simultaneously align with, reproduce, and critique racialised class positions known by the labels 'redneck', 'trash', 'hillbilly' or the hyphenate 'poor-whites', I draw on work in linguistic anthropology already being mobilised in the study of whiteness, especially in terms of indexicality (Kiesling, 2001; Ochs, 1992; Trechter & Bucholtz, 2001).

The people I interviewed with came from largely white, working-class communities. Lycoming County, PA, for example, home of Lycoming County Fair, is 94% white with only 15% of the population over 25 holding a bachelor's degree (US Government, 2007). The county's median household income is just \$36,891, with 12% living under the poverty line (compared to the Pennsylvania state average of \$43,714). With just over 5% of workers occupying executive, administrative, managerial or professional occupations, this is very much a working-class community, and derby entrants reflected this demographic. I did not perform a census, but the browned arms and faces of men in the crowd suggested that outdoor labour was common, and a preponderance of oxygen-assisted breathing, smoking and obesity (traits that tend to accompany insufficient preventative health care) further suggested

that these communities lack the privileges often associated with, but not in truth always present in, the middle-class white. In spot counts, I identified fewer than five non-whites at any derby, and coiffed urban-styled professionals, white and non-white alike, immediately stood out.

Derbiers are aware of terms denoting status, which is writ large through car labelling. In general, labels meant to denigrate racialised groups often index power relations, historical inequalities or social differences. Ugly epithets have become politically incorrect, and social movements based on unmasking their harms have resulted in the erasure of terms like 'wop', 'chink' and 'spic' from polite conversation. Possibly, the most charged racial expression in US vernacular is 'nigger', a term whose use is debated by citizens and scholars alike (Asim, 2007; Kennedy, 2002; Williams & Larkins, 2004), some arguing that no one should use it under any circumstances and others, like Michael Eric Dyson, embracing it as not only acceptable, but even 'beautiful' (Deberry in Kennedy, 37). I myself attended a talk by Jabari Asim on 'the N word' in which older National Association for the Advancement of Colored People audience members, underscoring the complex ways that class, generation or gender might interact with epithets, sparred with black youth, telling them, 'if you knew what we went through, you would never want to use this word'.

I present these hard-to-hear words as belonging to a category of verboten racialised language that does not routinely include terms referring to whites such as 'redneck', 'hillbilly', 'hick' and perhaps most meanly, 'white trash' or 'trailer trash'. But they also have the power to belittle: 'trash' was once used by middle- and upper-class whites as a distancing device against poor whites on the basis of style, income, morality, taste and even sense of personal decency and responsibility. Nonetheless, compared to 'spic' or 'chink', it remains relatively acceptable to use white epithets in public fora such as mass media.

In the 1960s, activists reclaimed 'Chicano', a term used to deride Mexican workers. Activists re-set its meaning, taking ownership over its use, giving the term a prideful connotation. And Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual and Transgender communities have usurped ownership of 'queer'. Oppositional use of epithets is risky because their power to harm remains intact. But this harmful potential is behind their productive power, or so say those who try to re-set meaning. Attempting to strip language of its mischief by highlighting its use as risky is underscored by the debates about 'the N word' within the African-US community. The use of 'white trash', 'hillbilly' and 'redneck' by derbiers in car naming operates in a similarly ambiguous fashion. As an act of creative destruction, there is a dangerous, critical – even a radical – irony to its appearance.

Like its upper-class cousin, horse racing, derby cars are owned and worked on by teams, families or companies, who together name their vehicles. Sometimes cars are given funny names like 'Never Die!' or 'Please Hit Me', while others take on appellations with distinct class overtones: Hillbilly Hunter, White Trash, Trash Deluxe or Yee Haw. To understand why, I talked with Junior Nason, driver of a colourfully decorated Buick Electra, 'sponsored' by an imaginary company called 'Redneck Customs', to describe his ideal derby car:

Mainly a car that runs good without any rust, one that you pick it up for a couple hundred bucks, or maybe free. I seen guys travel as far as South Carolina or Arizona for the right car. This one here was a gift from my half-brother, and it was just a body,

but mainly we get 'em word of mouth. We turned it into a good car though. It's custom-made.

Drivers like Junior spend afternoons scouting for cars, with networks of people participating as bricoleurs, gathering the detritus of society and reframing it to suit their own purposes. The consumer society is marked by disposability and planned obsolescence, and cars are no exception: derbiers find unwanted vehicles in old lots or alongside country roads (Don, a security guard, explained, 'My mechanic finds old cars, then keeps them hidden throughout the year. Then when it's time, BAM! He pulls them out and gets 'em ready') or buy them for a few bucks (usually no more than \$200), and rework them into useful, aesthetically pleasing objects.

Bourdieu's treatise on the role of taste in the reproduction of social hierarchy and Baudrillard's work on sign value have both advanced how we understand the formation of class through leisure, but they primarily worked with middle and elite urban whites (Baudrillard (1968) 1996; Bourdieu, 2000).⁶ Identity production for derby communities via aesthetics is no different, but trends originate within the community, rather than by emulation or corporate advertising. Kinship is practiced through participation in shared aesthetics, while individuals express humour and perspective through variation, in ways not unlike the quilting norms that facilitate community-building in North Carolina (Forrest, 1988). As a shared activity, expression, discussion and enjoyment of derby aesthetics strengthens communities.

That a half-brother gave Junior this car reflects his family involvement. Once they found the car, they began scavenging parts, which were retro-fitted on weekends or at night. The last step is painting and naming the car. Some cars are left raw (the 'natural', unmanaged look carries its own meaning), but many teams stencil flames or spray on vivid patterns. Others use a minimalist approach, sporting a monochromatic look with a striking name. Junior's team chose a gold, red and blue palette to complement their 'sponsor's' moniker: 'Redneck Customs'. For Junior, this 'good car' was made by family members – 'rednecks', working together to 'custom' build the car. But, the title has another meaning. Derbying is something that the Nason family, and others, do; it is a (wink) 'redneck custom', and in this way the car represents the group. This second meaning is in keeping with the practice of using labels to critique racialised class.

Junior clearly thought it was clever, making sure that I 'got it', by raising a brow at the end of his description. The Nasons are playing with labels bestowed upon them by middle- or upper-classed whites in the spirit of both critique and pride. This practice is hip (in the language of oppositional urbanite middle classes) in its knowing irony (which is amusing in that class irony is often viewed as a practice having been cornered by urban 'hipsters', pretending to be 'white trash' as a fashion statement). The term indexes class awareness (the meaning of these practices rely on the Nason's and my knowledge of unstated cultural norms and models (after Kiesling, 2001, p. 111), and as used here, is a bittersweet badge of belonging. The name 'Redneck Customs' operates as a marker and a maker of community insofar as its humour addresses an in-group and is a way of performing, and critiquing, their own subordinate whiteness. It also reproduces an internalised hierarchy. As a white, urban, middle-class academic, I found this practice tragic, surprising, smart, and poignant. Insofar as humour hinges on ambiguity and risk, I also found it hilarious (see Figure 2).



Figure 2. Junior Nason preparing 'Redneck Customs.' Photo by Author.

Another example is 'White Trash', the Oldsmobile crewed by 'Brian's Bunch', easily identified by their matching team shirts. 'White Trash' was in good shape and artfully festooned. When how they came up with the look, Brian explained, 'We name these cars or decorate them so they look tough, so they look baaaaad, this one's gonna shoot flames. Watch out!'

Brian's car, carefully painted in a streamlined white and black scheme, is impressive. I learned that 'White Trash', rendered in bold black lettering, is intentionally meaningful, helping to create a 'tough' and 'bad' look. This term could be read as derogatory, with 'white trash' describing a not-quite-white group. Those subject to these labels do not necessarily enjoy the privileges often associated with hegemonic whiteness, and are often depicted as stupid and vulgar (iconicised in the film 'Deliverance') or sweet, but innocent and bumbling (as in the 'Beverly Hillbilies'), and may be ridiculed in popular culture for the way they speak, dress and eat. Brian's Bunch is playfully calling themselves by a term through which they know some ruling whites see them, reclaiming ownership over the term in ways that spectacularise and appraise their own racialised class position. At another level, they mean to describe the car, which is white and also trashed, 'tough' and 'bad'. The semiotic of 'white trash' is anything but stupid, vulgar, innocent or bumbling: Bunch's 'White Trash', successfully deploys sophisticated irony as empowering critique.

Explaining humour is always treacherous, possibly defanging the joke. So, while I accept that my analysis might destroy or miss something, I will try to explicate these naming practices. By using names like White Trash, Hillbilly Hunter and Redneck Customs, drivers reclaim derisive terms, replacing them with mischievous significance. These semiotics recall a controversial portrait of Chris Rock appearing on the cover of *Vanity Fair* (1998) in which he appears in blackface. The power of Brian's 'White Trash', Junior's 'Redneck Customs' and Rock's blackface depends on an ambiguous, risky attempt to re-inscribe oppressive power, in breaking rules against complaints about racism, and in taking pride from within an identity *déclassé*. Their power to charge lies in their potential to flop.

At the derby, never belying their roots in a ruthlessly classed society, terms like 'trash' and 'redneck' can become humorous, prideful and ironic. Those subject to

derisive labelling become agents of their own transformation. This deconstruction and reclaiming of racialised class, as an expression of agency, can outlast the event itself. These workers, in recapturing the fruits of their labour by reversing the alienation that normally characterises their work with machines, enjoy the rewards of such action, even if only temporarily. When asked why they derby, drivers exclaimed, 'It's the greatest feeling in the world, you get your aggressions out' or 'Once you do, it you never want to stop'. I doubt anyone said this after the first day laying asphalt for minimum wage, a point I make primarily to highlight the emotive, subjective, liberatory value of participation, which includes naming the car (see Figure 3).

Conclusion

Creative destruction is exhilarating because it might emancipate, or contribute to further entrenchment of the status quo. The derby is exciting for all drivers, but for some, it is also empowering. This empowerment can be an end in itself, encouraging people to inhabit an alternative consciousness, a different space from which to see themselves. I have tried to show how this works on the level of racialised class, but there are other ways in which this can function. Consider Ricky's story. Ricky posed in front of his car while we talked about how he got into derbying, which he has been doing for over a decade. 'I really consider this to be a competitive sport. You can't tell maybe, but I am a double amputee, and this is the one place that I can be an equal competitor'. He was right. I had not noticed that he was an amputee. And he did, in fact, win his heat a few hours later. Through this activity, Ricky generates a sense of esteem and equality, perhaps even manliness, unequalled in other areas of his life.⁷ Derbying does more than release tension, it changes the way he understands himself.

The derby's radical potential is manifest in elation, a feeling brought about by rule breaking, risk taking and in Nietzsche's terminology, exerting the will to power (Nietzsche, (1883–1885) 1978). For derbyers, plying one's skills and labour for oneself, finding an alternative to profit-driven spaces in which to practice kinship and community building, and reframing racialised class terms are a rush. Participants



Figure 3. Ricky with #26. Photo by Author.

generate a forum for self-expression, for macho sensuality, and for opening themselves to the unknown. They are creators, self-enhancers, and like Nietzsche's 'noble man', work against the conservative forces of the 'good and the just' towards liberation. The derby then, for drivers and audience alike, is a rite of reversal that reproduces the status quo, but also contains a radical potential in that its effects can spill outside the bracketed arena to transform participants' lives in small but exciting and unpredictable ways.

Notes

1. Indeed, photographers like Michael Carlebach have shown that places like the derby are excellent 'sideways' windows into American Culture. See Carlebach (2011).
2. Analysis of FEC data by Center for Responsive Politics/USA Today retrieved from http://www.usatoday.com/news/politics/2007-06-14-carmaker-contributions_N.htm.
3. There are 2.4 million jobs in the private sector attributable to the auto industry and its suppliers, and 4.7 million when all indirect spin-off effects are included. These jobs exist because the industry depends upon steel, aluminium, technology, fabric, rubber, transport and so forth upstream, and repair, parking, highway transport, sales, advertising and salvage and other industry downstream, radiating outwards in multiple directions with varying degrees of intensity (McAlinden et al., 2003).
4. Sombart (1863–1941) was a leading economist of the Younger German Historical School of Economics.
5. There are many excellent studies on whiteness – I have listed only a few significant studies.
6. See Halle (1993).
7. Derbies are mostly for men, and women who do it are considered 'tough,' reflected in Jason's remark that, 'Most of these guys out here are in it for the glory, for the rush, although there are some girls out here. There's probably about fifteen girls and sometimes they do a special 'powderpuff' derby, but usually there aren't enough. And when there is a girl out here, we don't take it easy on her. Last time I did that, she about flipped my car over, so they don't get any special treatment.' For more on gender, see Haller (2003).

Notes on contributor

Susan Falls teaches anthropology at the Savannah College of Art and Design. Her research interests include aesthetics, material culture, semiotics and political economy. She has written about the diamond industry, the Khmer *ikat* silk trade, and public art. She can be reached at sfalls@scad.edu

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